

Q I'm experiencing what feel like mild labor pains. What's happening?

Your uterus doesn't stop working right after the delivery. Having stretched ten-fold during pregnancy, it begins the job of returning to its pre-pregnancy size—a process known as involution.

As your uterus shrinks back down, you will experience cramping pains, like mild labor contractions, commonly called “after pains.” These are generally quite manageable, especially in a first pregnancy, when the previously unstretched muscles are stronger and able to contract back down more easily.

If you do find the pains too much to bear, seek advice from your doctor. You can take acetaminophen for the pain and you can also try using the breathing techniques you used in labor. You may notice

that the pains are stronger when you breast-feed; this is because the hormone oxytocin released during breast-feeding to let down your milk is the same one that encouraged uterine contractions. While you may not welcome the stronger sensation, breast-feeding helps your uterus to contract back down more quickly. It takes up to six weeks for your uterus to get back to its pre-pregnancy size. Pains are usually felt most strongly in the first week or so, and many women find they are barely noticeable after this time.

YOUR SHRINKING UTERUS

Within a couple of days of the birth, your uterus will be the size it was about midway through your pregnancy. It will then rapidly reduce in size, until at about six weeks after birth it is no bigger than a plum (the size it is pre-pregnancy).



Q I'm shocked by the heavy bleeding. Is this normal?

It's completely normal: as the uterus shrinks, it sheds blood and tissue called lochia. At first it's like a heavy period, but then tails off. Lochia changes from red to a watery pink color, and then becomes a yellowy discharge. Wear a sanitary pad since a tampon could infect the uterus. Heavy bleeding can last up to two weeks. Seek medical help if: the bleeding becomes heavy and red again after having lightened; is so heavy that you need more than one sanitary pad an hour; you pass large clots of blood; the discharge is smelly; or you feel feverish or dizzy. Excessive bleeding anytime from 24

hours to six weeks after the birth is known as secondary postpartum hemorrhage (PPH). This may happen because part of the placenta is still attached to the lining of the uterus.

Q When is my follow-up appointment and what will the OB/GYN check?

Your “six-week checkup” can take place six to eight weeks after the birth, (your bleeding/lochia should have stopped flowing by then).

The doctor will check your blood pressure and examine your abdomen to make sure that your uterus has returned to the correct size. Your doctor may examine any stitches or scars to

check that everything has healed. Make an appointment sooner if you have any physical effects of breast-feeding (e.g. blocked milk ducts or mastitis) that need treatment. Your doctor will also advise you about contraception. This is a chance to talk about how you're feeling, so be honest so he or she can direct you to support.

It is possible to become pregnant while you are still breast-feeding, so don't rely on it as a form of contraception.